

Canadian Literature, Grade 11

University/College Preparation

ETC3M

This course emphasizes the study and analysis of literary texts by Canadian authors for students with a special interest in Canadian literature. Students will study the themes, forms, and stylistic elements of a variety of literary texts representative of various time periods and of the diverse cultures and regions of Canada, and will respond personally, critically, and creatively to them.

Prerequisite: English, Grade 10, Academic or Applied

Strands

The expectations in this course are organized into a single strand.

CANADIAN LITERATURE

OVERALL EXPECTATIONS

By the end of this course, students will:

- 1. Understanding Texts:** read and demonstrate an understanding of a variety of Canadian literary texts from different cultures, regions, and historical periods;
- 2. Analysing Texts:** respond to and analyse Canadian literary texts to develop and extend their understanding of how content, form, and style in combination communicate meaning and enhance a text's effectiveness;
- 3. Critical Literacy:** demonstrate an understanding that Canadian authors, readers, and texts have particular perspectives that influence the reading experience;
- 4. Literary Criticism:** use literary criticism to enhance their understanding of Canadian literature;
- 5. The Role of Literature in Society:** assess the importance of Canadian literature as a social and cultural force.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

1. Understanding Texts

By the end of this course, students will:

Variety of Texts

- 1.1** read a variety of types of Canadian literary texts by authors from different backgrounds, regions, and time periods (*e.g., create a regional bibliography of Canadian texts to show a timeline of major works of the twentieth and twenty-first centuries; compare how several authors treat the immigrant experience; keep a list of unfamiliar and/or distinctive Canadian words and expressions while reading a play; generate a list of award-winning Canadian stage, film, and television dramas, and identify elements those works have in common*)

Teacher prompts: "What similarities do you see in the works of these Canadian playwrights?" "Do you know of other Canadian poets who explore this theme?"

Reading With a Purpose

- 1.2** identify the purpose (or purposes) for reading particular Canadian literary texts (*e.g., an essay by a Canadian author, to identify the author's perspective or bias; a literary reference text, for information about Canadian motifs, archetypes, and themes; a website, for information about contemporary Canadian authors*)

Teacher prompts: "Why have you selected this particular Canadian author as a focus for intensive study?" "What information on the website would be useful in helping you to select a Canadian poet for intensive study?"

Using Reading Comprehension Strategies

- 1.3** identify a variety of reading comprehension strategies and use them before, during, and after reading to enhance their understanding of Canadian literary texts (*e.g., develop a series of questions while reading a text; use margin notes to show the structural relationship between the beginning, middle, and end of a poem; use graphic organizers to show the plot structure of a novel and to track the relationships between characters*)

Teacher prompt: "How can online journal exchanges with your reading partner help you to understand confusing passages in the text?"

2. Analysing Texts

By the end of this course, students will:

Responding to Texts

- 2.1** respond to Canadian literary texts in a variety of ways, before, during, and after reading, to extend their understanding of the ideas, themes, and issues explored in the texts

(e.g., write an additional scene for a Canadian play to provide new insight into its theme; write a poem reflecting the view about a regional or cultural identity expressed in a Canadian text; use visual means, such as a scrapbook, to represent personal connections they have made to Canadian texts; write a letter to a Canadian author expressing respect and admiration for the author's work or asking questions about it; create a CD cover and a playlist of songs by Canadian artists that reflect the ideas, themes, or issues explored in a Canadian text; use readers' theatre to dramatize a text passage that highlights some aspect of Canadian identity; debate opposing views about the societal impact of the First World War presented in texts by two Canadian authors; create a concept map to trace the evolving use and significance of a motif in a Canadian text)

Teacher prompts: "What are your initial impressions of the novel, based on your reading of the first chapter?" "What questions have emerged from your study of a Canadian writer that you would like to focus on in your seminar presentation?"

Exploring Background Information

2.2 use information from secondary sources to understand how historical, political, regional, and cultural contexts influence the presentation of ideas, issues, and themes in Canadian literary texts (e.g., research the social and economic context of works that depict the Aboriginal or immigrant experience; create a web page linking excerpts from a text to historical photographs; research cultural beliefs, such as ideas about gender roles or religion, that significantly influence the actions of characters in a novel)

Teacher prompts: "What influence did geography have on the character's development?" "Do historians differ significantly in their interpretation of the historical events depicted in the novel? Which historian's view of the event is closest to that of the author?"

Analysing Texts

2.3 analyse Canadian literary texts in terms of the information, ideas, issues, and themes they explore, providing evidence from the texts to support their analysis (e.g., in a graphic organizer, record inferences made about a character based on the speech and actions of the character; outline the principal conflicts in a text and explain the themes that emerge as those conflicts are resolved; identify an object, phrase, or action associated with a character, incident, or theme in a text and explain the connection)

Teacher prompts: "What evidence from the text supports your explanation of the character's motives?" "What specific quotations from the poem support your interpretation of its theme?" "Does your interpretation of this scene in the play help you understand its purpose in the play's overall structure?"

Text Forms

2.4 explain how the characteristics of different literary text forms help communicate meaning in a variety of Canadian literary texts (e.g., use a multimedia presentation to illustrate how changes in narrative point of view create multiple layers of meaning in a novel by one of Canada's Aboriginal writers; adapt a scene from one form of text – such as a short story – to suit a different form – such as a film script; compare the treatment of the same theme or issue in a play and a poem to explore how form affects meaning)

Teacher prompts: "What effect has the writer achieved by using several different text forms within one work?" "How does the addition of music in a film version of a play contribute to our understanding of a scene?" "Why do you think the author uses dialogue so much? Is the dialogue used mainly to reveal character, or to advance the plot, or both?"

Elements of Style

2.5 identify various elements of style used in Canadian literary texts and explain how they help communicate meaning and enhance the effectiveness of the text (e.g., identify figurative devices used in a poem and explain how they express or clarify the theme; explain how the use of regional or cultural dialects in a text contributes to the depiction of character and amplifies the theme; explain the effect of the use of multiple narrators in a novel; identify and demonstrate an understanding of the role of rhetorical devices used in a Canadian text by incorporating them into a written appreciation of the text)

Teacher prompts: "How does the author's use of regional dialect in both narration and dialogue clarify the theme of the story?" "What types of imagery has the poet used, and what is the effect of juxtaposing the different types of images?"

3. Critical Literacy

By the end of this course, students will:

The Author's Perspective

- 3.1** demonstrate an understanding of how a Canadian author's writing has been influenced by factors such as gender, time period, cultural background, and social and political conditions and events (*e.g., relate themes and events in a text to biographical information about the author; use materials from a variety of online and print sources to create a collage illustrating relevant aspects of the period when a novel was written; relate the work of selected Canadian women writers to movements for social change in Canada; relate the work of selected Aboriginal authors to historical, political, or social developments that affected the lives of Aboriginal peoples in Canada*)

Teacher prompt: "Is there evidence in the story that the author was influenced by significant historical or political events?"

Audience Perspectives

- 3.2** analyse Canadian literary texts in terms of how social, cultural, and regional contexts and different readers' perspectives may influence readers' interpretations of the texts (*e.g., predict responses in different regions of Canada to texts that focus on the theme of "two solitudes"; predict the responses of people from different social, cultural, and political backgrounds to texts that focus on the immigrant experience; compare the treatment of a theme in a Canadian text to the treatment of the same theme in texts from other countries and suggest reasons for the similarities and differences; explain why they think a particular text does or does not have the ability to "resonate with" a broad spectrum of diverse groups in Canada*)

Teacher prompts: "How do you think your experiences as a young man/woman have influenced your response to this text?" "What examples can you think of that show how a reader's background knowledge and experience influence the way he or she constructs meaning when reading?"

Perspectives in the Text

- 3.3** analyse Canadian literary texts to identify particular perspectives presented in them and the stylistic and/or structural means used to communicate those perspectives (*e.g., identify whose perspective(s) or psychology is/are foregrounded in a text – those of characters from "mainstream" society or those of characters in a "marginal" position in society; identify the*

regional or cultural positions, voices, and interests represented in a text and explain how language, imagery, and structure are used to communicate information about them)

Teacher prompts: "Does the text present an unconventional perspective on the issues it raises? Do you support or oppose this perspective, and why?" "What do you infer from the fact that some characters in the text are 'rounded' while others seem to be stereotypes or even caricatures?"

4. Literary Criticism

By the end of this course, students will:

Understanding Literary Concepts and Terms

- 4.1** demonstrate an understanding of key concepts and specialized terms that are used in literary criticism focusing on Canadian literary texts (*e.g., consult a dictionary or glossary of literary terms, or specialized reference sources, to determine the meaning of unfamiliar terminology and allusions, and keep a record of their findings; explain concepts and specialized language used in critical interpretations of drama, fiction, or poetry; use relevant literary concepts and terms to identify and describe the conventions employed in texts in various genres, consulting appropriate references and works of criticism for clarification when necessary*)

Teacher prompt: "What new critical terminology have you learned that has helped you to express your ideas about the work of a particular Canadian writer?"

Applying Concepts

- 4.2** use key concepts or approaches of literary criticism to help them analyse and interpret Canadian literary texts (*e.g., in a classroom discussion, explain how the theory of archetypes helps in the interpretation of a short story; in a seminar presentation, interpret a text in the light of a particular critical approach or literary theory; use a Marxist or feminist critical perspective to determine which characters in a novel hold power*)

Teacher prompt: "Which approach to literary criticism have you found most helpful in extending your understanding of the text and/or writer you are studying?"

Researching and Evaluating Critical Interpretations

- 4.3** assess critical interpretations found in print and electronic sources to extend their understanding of specific works of Canadian literature (*e.g., write a brief synopsis of a critical article*

and assess the degree to which it increases their understanding of a Canadian play; use a graphic organizer to summarize the key points in two book reviews; using an appropriate example as a model, write a critical review of a Canadian text; write a short report identifying the strengths and weaknesses of several different critiques of a familiar Canadian text; critique a postmodern analysis of a contemporary Canadian text; write an evaluation of a critical work that analyses a dominant theme in Canadian literature)

Teacher prompt: “What new insights have you gained as a result of reading and discussing literary criticism about the text you are studying?”

Assessing Peer Critical Responses

4.4 analyse peers’ critical responses to Canadian literary texts to clarify and extend their own understanding of those texts (e.g., *record, reflect on, and respond to group members’ interpretations of a section of a Canadian novel; write a commentary on a peer’s analysis of a text, noting the most useful insights and challenging possible misinterpretations*)

Teacher prompts: “To what extent do the ideas presented in the seminar group challenge or support your own reading of the text?” “Have the responses of others changed your own ideas about the meaning of the text? Why or why not?”

5. The Role of Literature in Society

By the end of this course, students will:

Fostering Social, Cultural, and Political Awareness

5.1 explain how Canadian literary texts raise awareness about a variety of regional issues, ideas, cultures, events, and people (e.g., *identify overt or implied positions on issues taken in texts; explain how the work of a favourite Canadian author has influenced their thinking about a social issue; identify works that have fuelled debate on a national level about a social, cultural, or political issue; explain the role of Canadian literary works in building understanding of the diversity of the population, and identify specific works that have contributed to such understanding*)

Teacher prompt: “What have you learned about a specific issue in Canadian culture from studying Canadian plays?”

Engaging the Intellect and the Imagination

5.2 identify ways in which Canadian literary texts can promote readers’ intellectual and imaginative growth (e.g., *reflect in a journal about how the futuristic vision presented in a text might influence a reader’s thinking and behaviour; explain, orally or in writing, why they want to follow a particular character’s journey beyond the last page of the text; write a personal essay exploring how depictions of characters in a community in a text have expanded their mental horizons; write a letter to a friend sharing how reading a particular text has helped them cope with a difficult situation*)

Teacher prompt: “What aspects of the novel did you find most thought-provoking?”

Promoting Personal and Social Change

5.3 identify ways in which Canadian literary texts might promote social and personal change (e.g., *use a graphic organizer to relate a conflict depicted in a text to the changing social or cultural values of its time; write and deliver a speech that a character from a contemporary text might make to spur an audience to social action; write an editorial recommending corrective action to remedy an abuse depicted in a text; use a graphic organizer to compare opposing depictions of a cultural group in texts from two different historical periods and suggest reasons for the differences; identify a text that depicts social or economic inequity and do research to determine whether the situation it describes has improved, and if so, in what way*)

Teacher prompts: “Has reading a specific Canadian text prompted you to re-examine an event in Canadian history?” “What issue portrayed in your readings in the course seems most important to you? Why?”

Exploring Canadian Identity

5.4 explain how Canadian literary texts have contributed to their understanding of a Canadian identity (e.g., *predict how the lives of the characters in a story might change if the story were set in a different part of the country, or a country other than Canada; compare book reviews of a novel by Canadian and international reviewers and suggest reasons for the differences; prepare an oral presentation about “survival” as a dominant theme in Canadian literature; write an essay discussing how particular texts reveal diverse facets of the Canadian “character” or identity*)

Teacher prompts: “What recurring themes have emerged in this course that shed light on what it means to be Canadian?” “How have the course readings increased your

understanding of the experiences of other Canadians?" "What Canadian novelists have the greatest international sales? How would we find this information?"

Developing Personal Awareness

5.5 explain how their study of Canadian literature has enhanced their understanding of themselves as readers and as individuals (*e.g., explain in a journal entry how their ideas about an issue or theme have been influenced by their reading in the course; in a small group seminar, model a reading strategy that helped them understand and interpret a passage in a course text*)

Teacher prompts: "Did the discussion in the seminar group persuade you to modify your initial reaction to the text?" "What insights into a major theme in the text did you gain from the close reading and analysis of selected passages?" "Which texts in the course resonate most with your own experiences or perceptions?"